

STURGEON

by

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In a steel mill in Gary, Indiana, an old foreman must choose between selling an antiquated wrench for a fortune or using it to perform one last act of labor to save the building from collapse during a power outage. The play explores the tension between America's steel industrial past and its digital silicon future.

Cast of Characters

Lippmann (70s, Man) is an old-school foreman who values the physical utility and heritage of steel over technology.

Goodwin (20s, Woman) is Lippmann's pragmatic granddaughter who views his Sturgeon as an exit strategy to escape a dying industry.

Bernays (40s, Man) is a high-stakes buyer who treats industrial history as gold.

Settings

Gary, Indiana

The Office is a space suspended like a "bird's nest" above the mill floor, featuring cracked windows and a manual punch clock.

The Sub-Basement is cathedral of screaming metal two levels down, containing the Boiler Room where black, oily water from Lake Michigan sweeps through the floorboards.

Lake Michigan is an atmosphere where the sound of waves hitting pilings is constant and the air smells perpetually of kerosene.

Props

- The "Sturgeon" is a forged 30-pound Grade-8 iron wrench with a notched head.
- The Log (1926-1988) is a leather ledger covered in dust that records every turn of the wrench and the name of all who used it.
- Bernays's briefcase and tablet with ultrasonic scans.
- The Transistor Radio is a device held together by duct tape.

PROLOGUE

OLD STEEL MILL IN GARY, INDIANA

The office is suspended above the main floor like a bird's nest. Outside, Lake Michigan is an unseen beast. Every four seconds, the pilings shudder.

A hum of wind whistles through cracked glass, punctuated by the metallic clink of cooling pipes.

AT RISE: LIPPMANN (70s) is alone. He looks like the furniture. He is performing a ritual he has done for forty years.

Lippmann opens a rusted tin of kerosene. He dips a rag into the fluid. He begins to scrub his wrench which he calls the STURGEON. He uses a Zippo lighter to check his progress. The flame reflects the black iron of the wrench.

Lippmann stands and walks to the windows. He looks out at the horizon where the Chicago skyline should be.

He picks up a thermos (dented, stainless steel) and pours a cup of coffee.

He speaks to the empty room.

LIPPMANN

Still holding, boys. Still holding.

He checks a manual punch clock on the wall. It's been dead since the 80s, but he moves the hand forward one minute.

The sound of a Tesla's high-pitched electric whine cuts through the industrial silence from far below. It sounds like a mosquito in a cathedral. He sets the Sturgeon down on a piece of velvet and waits at his desk.

SCENE 1

AN OLD STEEL MILL IN GARY, INDIANA

Lippmann pulls out a Transistor Radio, held together by duct tape, and plays "I Want You Back" from the Jackson 5, natives of Gary, Indiana.

GOODWIN (20s) enters. She wears an expensive puffer vest that looks out of place against the soot.

GOODWIN

Are you kidding me with those stairs? I almost lost an ankle.

Lippmann turns off the radio.

LIPPMANN

Hopefully it's because you were dancing up.

GOODWIN

Nah... Also, the gate? I had to squeeze through the side-rail. My vest is trashed.

LIPPMANN

You're supposed to use the manual release. Big red handle. Can't miss it.

GOODWIN

Yeah, I saw it. It looked like it'd give me tetanus.

Goodwin sniffs the air.

GOODWIN (CONT'D)

God. Can't get enough of the kerosene, huh?

LIPPMANN

Keeps the rust off. You get used to it after ten minutes.

Goodwin checks the time on her phone.

GOODWIN

Nothing. Not even a single bar.

LIPPMANN

Besides steel, I've got iron bars you can borrow.

GOODWIN

I've got zero service. Like, dead zero. I'm trying to track a trade. Even the time is off.

LIPPMANN

The waves hit the pilings every four seconds. That's the only clock this building needs.

GOODWIN

The market doesn't care about the lake. The developers definitely don't. They're ready to gut this mill.

LIPPMANN

They'll have to get through our family first.

GOODWIN

Our family is already falling apart, Lippmann. Have you seen your son lately? Really seen him?

LIPPMANN

He's a bit winded. The winter's always been hard on him.

GOODWIN

It's not the snow. It's the walls. It's forty years of breathing in every spark and filing this building ever produced. It's siderosis, grandpa. Dad's lungs are turning into iron.

Lippmann stops rubbing the Sturgeon. He looks at her.

LIPPMANN

He never said...

GOODWIN

Like father like son. He's just like you. He thinks grit is a substitute for oxygen. But the insurance won't pay for the new treatments, and this mill doesn't cover a mortgage in Gary.

LIPPMANN

(Quietly)

The Sturgeon is a key, Goodwin.

GOODWIN

Then let it unlock a life for him! Bernays's buyer is a boutique hotel in Grand Rapids. They want it under a spotlight in the lobby. It's worth six figures in crypto. Six. You could get him the specialists. You could move him somewhere the air doesn't smell like kerosene.

LIPPMANN

A spotlight... That iron's never seen a light that wasn't a spark from a forge or a flare in a storm.

GOODWIN

It's a tribute to the American steel industry!

LIPPMANN

They want to nail a piece of this frontier to a wall in a lobby so people can drink expensive coffee and talk about the way things were.

GOODWIN

I'm asking you to walk away! You could never have to hear a wave hit a rock again.

LIPPMANN

And instead hear beep bap boop from a computer. If I sell this, the building dies.

GOODWIN

The building is already a corpse! The fires are out, the men are gone. It's just a carcass, Lippmann. Let him take the bone.

Goodwin shakes her phone in frustration.

GOODWIN (CONT'D)

Still nothing. Total blackout. How do you even order a pizza in this tomb?

LIPPMANN

I don't want pizza. I want the lake to stay on the other side of that glass.

GOODWIN

(Pacing)

It's not 1974. You're sitting in a rust bucket waiting for a heart attack.

LIPPMANN

Stone me with the reality, why don't ya?

GOODWIN

My phone's been a brick, and Bernays is downstairs in a Tesla worth more than this entire zip code—

LIPPMANN

He's sitting in a glass carriage.

GOODWIN
(Mockingly)

What's a carriage?

LIPPMANN
You kiddos make me lose my mind.

GOODWIN
Well, Bernays is losing patience.

Lippmann sets the wrench down.

LIPPMANN
Then let him lose it. It's the only thing he's
got left to lose.

GOODWIN
Drop the Zen act, grandpa.

LIPPMANN
I ain't Zen.

GOODWIN
Please. He's offering an exit strategy.

LIPPMANN
My life enters with steel. My life will exit
with steel.

GOODWIN
Our family needs to enter real money. "Never
wear wool again" money.

LIPPMANN
You think he wants a tool? Look at it, Goodwin.
That's thirty pounds of Grade-8 spite.

GOODWIN
I don't know what that means.

LIPPMANN
Your pal wants a conversation piece. He wants
to put it behind plexiglass so some guy in a
suit can stare at it while he eats an
overpriced avocado.

GOODWIN
Not the avocado toast talk-

LIPPMANN
Your generation needs to go back to apple
orchards!

GOODWIN

He wants to save the Sturgeon like an orchard.

LIPPMANN

Nah. He wants to taxidermy it.

GOODWIN

(Leaning over the desk)

The city is cutting the power in sixty days.
When the pumps stop, this office becomes a
reef. The Sturgeon will be under twenty feet of
Great Lakes filth.

LIPPMANN

As Lake Sturgeons should be-

GOODWIN

Who's respecting the steel then? The fish?

LIPPMANN

Steel is the heart of this country.

GOODWIN

And so was gold. But now it's crypto.

LIPPMANN

Crypto ain't liquidity. And the pumps aren't
what's keeping us dry, Goodwin. Forget how
pressure works?

GOODWIN

I know how liquidity works. You're sitting on a
winning lottery ticket and using it as a
doorstop.

Lippmann picks up the wrench
again.

LIPPMANN

The a stopper. There's a valve in the sub-
basement of the main steam line that hasn't
been turned since Reagan was in office. It's
seized.

GOODWIN

You're like those old dads who hold onto a
piece of wood or cord because maybe one day
it'll be useful kinda useful.

LIPPMANN

So is your dad and my dad before me.

GOODWIN

Ugh.

LIPPMANN

Look if a lake surge hits the boiler lines and that valve isn't cracked... this whole place not only floods. It implodes.

GOODWIN

So call a plumber!

LIPPMANN

(Laughing)

A plumber? With a website and a kidnapper van? They'd see that valve and run. This is the only tool that fits the nut. Custom forged in '52. One tool. One job.

Lippman stands in front of Goodwin, like a cowboy in an old spaghetti western. He prepares to duel. Then draws to hold out the wrench like a pistol.

LIPPMANN (CONT'D)

Hold it.

GOODWIN

Lippmann, come on.

LIPPMANN

Hold the damn thing. If you know this is a steal, you should know what was used to make the first steel furniture in America.

Goodwin tucks her phone into her vest and reaches out.

GOODWIN

Fine. Give it—

Lippmann lets go a fraction of a second too early. The weight nearly yanks Goodwin over the desk. She grunts.

GOODWIN (CONT'D)

Jesus! Is this thing lead-lined?

LIPPMANN

Mesabi Range iron.

GOODWIN

Mesabi?

LIPPMANN

Mesabi Range is a major mining district in Minnesota and the largest of its four iron ranges.

GOODWIN

Good ol' Midwest mining.

LIPPMANN

This is also smelted when the air in this town was orange and the men were made of the same stuff. Your grandpa carried that up three flights during the '75 freeze. No elevators. Just grit and black coffee.

GOODWIN

Yeah, and it probably blew out your cuffs. Look at the pitting, grandpa. It's corroding.

LIPPMANN

It ain't corrosion. That's character. Every one of those nicks is a time the world tried to break this building and this wrench said "no." See that notch near the head?

Goodwin tries to set it down on the desk, but Lippmann blocks her.

GOODWIN

I see it. Can I put it down now?

LIPPMANN

That notch is from the night the intake pipe froze solid. The lake tried to move in.

GOODWIN

Oh dear.

LIPPMANN

Your dad and I spent twelve hours in the dark, chest-deep in slush, hammering on this handle just to move the steam. If it had snapped, there'd be a parking lot here now.

GOODWIN

Dad never told me that. He just said he hated the smell of this place.

LIPPMANN

He hated the weight of it. Most people do. They want everything to be light. Like your phone.

GOODWIN

And soon it's a load off your back.

LIPPMANN

Hotel is nothing to make light of.

GOODWIN

It'll have a bar with artisanal ice. Why is that worse than drowning in slush? Why do you want to be the captain of a sinking ship?

LIPPMANN

Because I know what's under the floorboards. You think the future is all fiber optics? It'll always be the steel mill's spirits.

GOODWIN

"Steel mill's spirits." You should write a blog about that. Oh wait- no internet...

LIPPMANN

(Pointing to the floor)

Two levels down. The Boiler Room. It's weeping, Goodwin. The lake has been pushing for eighty years, and the only thing pushing back is a steel plate and a valve that needs my Sturgeon.

GOODWIN

Bernays isn't a bad guy. He's a bridge away from this graveyard. Listen to him. For me.

A heavy, rhythmic thudding starts from below. Boots on metal stairs. Slow. Deliberate.

LIPPMANN

(Eyes on the door)

That him?

Goodwin straightens her vest, checks her reflection on her dead phone screen.

GOODWIN

That's him. Smile, grandpa. Look like a future millionaire. He's going to ask about provenance.

LIPPMANN

Yes, Jesus's birth...

GOODWIN

Geez... Tell the Mesabi story.

LIPPMANN

They need to hear what's going on in Minnesota.

GOODWIN

Buyers love their facts *ironed* out. It sells the soul.

LIPPMANN

My soul isn't for sale. Just my iron.

GOODWIN

In this market, they're the same thing.

A dark silhouette appears behind the frosted glass of the door. Lippmann thumps a heavy, leather-bound ledger down next to the Sturgeon.

LIPPMANN

You want provenance? Open that.

GOODWIN

What is it?

LIPPMANN

The Log. From 1926 to 1988. Every turn of that wrench is recorded in there... every pound of pressure, every man who signed his life away alongside that tool.

Goodwin flips it open, coughing as a cloud of dust rises.

GOODWIN

It smells like a damp basement.

LIPPMANN

It smells like history.

GOODWIN

(Reading)

Miller... Paski...

LIPPMANN

Smith... Look at all those names. Names that have vanished. Those men had no investment portfolios. They got shifts. And they had the Sturgeon.

GOODWIN

(Reading)

June 14th, 1944. Valve 4-C seized. Three hours to crack it. Sturgeon used.

As Goodwin touches the grease on the ledger, the flickering office lights bleed into a chemical orange. The sound of the lake waves is replaced by the industrial mill in its prime.

The office becomes a ghostly shell. In the center, lit by a amber glow, is young Lippmann (20s). He is in orange light, fighting a valve with the Sturgeon. Goodwin stands on the periphery, watching her own grandfather as a young man.

YOUNG LIPPMANN

(Screaming at an unseen worker)

The packing is frozen solid! If the pressure hits the turbine, Gary goes dark!

Lippman slams the Sturgeon onto the valve. The sound is like a cannon shot. He heaves, his muscles straining, his face slick with orange-tinted sweat.

YOUNG LIPPMANN

(To himself, a prayer)

Just one more turn. Just one more for my child.

Lippman looks toward the spot where Goodwin stands in the future. He doesn't see her, but he's talking to the idea of her.

YOUNG LIPPMANN

You're gonna have a life of light, little bird. I'm breathing this lead so you can breathe air that smells like nothing at all. I'm gonna turn this iron until your world is all gold and no weight.

Lippman gives a primal heave. The orange light flares blindingly bright.

YOUNG LIPPMANN (CONT'D (CONT'D))

You hear me? I'm taking the weight off ya!

A massive metallic CRACK. The orange light begins to swirl, mixing with the cold black water of the present.

The industrial roar silences. The orange light snaps to a flickering blue. We are back in the present. Goodwin looks up from the log, unimpressed.

GOODWIN

That's it? That's the big drama? "Sturgeon used"?

LIPPMANN

In '44, "Sturgeon used" meant Chicago got the steel it needed for the rails. It meant the lights stayed on in hospitals. It helped societies continue their heartbeat.

Goodwin closes the book.

GOODWIN

And now that heart belongs in a museum.

The door creaks open. BERNAYS (40s) stands there, impeccably dressed in a cashmere coat and leather gloves. His smile looks as calculated as a computer program. He carries a slim, aluminum briefcase.

BERNAYS

This mill is a museum. I actually got lost in it.

GOODWIN

For how long you took to get up here, we might as well be part of the exhibits.

BERNAYS

(Inhaling deeply)

Kerosene and history. My favorite cocktail.

GOODWIN

You deserve a wine cellar for making it up the stairs.

LIPPMANN

Sorry about the inoperable elevator. It's been dead since... well, the Carter administration.

Bernays sees the Sturgeon.

BERNAYS

It's larger than the photos. They don't capture its sheer brutality.

LIPPMANN

It ain't no painting.

Bernays pulls off a glove. He
shakes Lippmann's hand.

BERNAYS

Goodwin's grandfather, Lippmann. Name's
Bernays. Thanks for inviting me to your steel
mill.

LIPPMANN

Thank you for inviting me to your headquarters.

BERNAYS

Perhaps next time you'll come to me next time.

LIPPMANN

Don't like Gary, Indiana?

BERNAYS

Umm...

LIPPMANN

I kid. I don't even.

BERNAYS

Well, I must say again that everything here in
this city is a painting. Sturgeon is a Jackson
Pollock of rust and sweat. It's magnificent.
May I?

LIPPMANN

It's heavy.

BERNAYS

I'm familiar with the weight of things.

Bernays reaches out, but he
doesn't grab the handle. He runs a
gloved finger along the head of
the Sturgeon, tracing its nicks.
He looks at his finger—a smudge of
black grease.

BERNAYS (CONT'D)

You can't 3D print this kind of wear.

GOODWIN

Lippmann was just telling me about the '75
freeze.

Bernays opens his briefcase on the edge of the desk. He pulls out a tablet.

BERNAYS

Save the stories for the museums' didactic panels, Goodwin.

Bernays sets down a glowing device.

BERNAYS (CONT'D)

Do you mind, Lippmann? It's an ultrasonic scan.

LIPPMANN

(Sarcastically)

Bigger than sonic? Fancy...

BERNAYS

I must ensure there are no internal fractures. The buyer is picky. They don't want it snapping if a tourist leans on the display case.

LIPPMANN

If it hasn't snapped in eighty years, no tourist can hurt it.

The device whines.

BERNAYS

Time is its own kind of pressure. Metal fatigues just like people do.

GOODWIN

Bernays's firm sold those old gear in Pittsburgh. They turned the turbines into lighting for a tech campus. It was beautiful.

LIPPMANN

Lighting fixtures. From turbines that powered an entire city.

BERNAYS

Energy is never lost; it's just redirected. Right now, the energy in this room is "dead capital." I'm here to turn it back into a current.

LIPPMANN

Is that what you call it?

BERNAYS

I call it evolution. Look at this scan.

Bernays turns the tablet towards Lippmann. The Sturgeon is rendered in wireframes.

BERNAYS (CONT'D)

Beautiful, isn't it? Stripped of the grease. Just pure geometry.

GOODWIN

Look at that density. Is that the Mesabi iron?

BERNAYS

A miracle of mid-century excess. They don't make them like this anymore.

LIPPMANN

Cause everything breaks now...

BERNAYS

I'm offering 0.48 Bitcoin. Based on this morning's market. Goodwin, tell him the number.

GOODWIN

(Shaky voice)

One hundred and twelve thousand dollars, Lippmann. For a wrench you haven't used since I wore diapers.

BERNAYS

With this, you'll never be *shit* outta luck.

Bernays only laughs at his own joke.

LIPPMANN

And what happens to the valve?

BERNAYS

The valve?

LIPPMANN

In the basement. The main steam line is seized, and this is the only tool that can open it. If the lake surges and that line isn't vented...

BERNAYS

Mr. Lippmann, this building is being gutted in six months. Engineers will seal that basement with five feet of waterproof concrete. Your valve is an obsolete relic.

LIPPMANN

Lake Michigan don't care if it's obsolete.

BERNAYS

The lake is now a "scenic view" for penthouses.
That's all.

The fluorescent lights flicker and
dim to a dull orange before
snapping back. The waves of the
lake vibrates through the floor.

Goodwin checks her phone again.

GOODWIN

Was that a power surge?

BERNAYS

This whole sector is a mess. That's even more
reason to move your liquidity into a secure
digital wallet before the local infrastructure
completely fails.

GOODWIN

That wasn't the power grid.

LIPPMANN

The ice shelf is breaking up early.

BERNAYS

We really upset the lake gods.

GOODWIN

Probably not the best idea to come here around
winter.

LIPPMANN

When that ice shifts, the pressure change slams
into the intake tunnels. The pumps are already
struggling to keep up.

Bernays checks his watch.

BERNAYS

Let's stay on track. Do we have a deal? The
transfer is ready to go. One tap on this screen
and you can retire.

Bernays turns the tablet.

LIPPMANN

You want to buy a tool you don't know how to
use, just to display it for people who won't
understand what it's for.

BERNAYS

I'm buying its story, Lippmann. Then and now, ideas has always been worth more than the object.

LIPPMANN

You want a story for your hotel lobby? This isn't just Mesabi iron. The core of this wrench was a 6-pounder field gun at Yorktown. It was melted down for the rails that tied the coasts together in 1869. Then it was folded into a turbine blade, and finally, it was beaten into this. It's seen every fire this nation ever lit-

GOODWIN

Alright, my old man can't stop talking about the good ol' days. Just look at the screen! It's a simple authentication process-

LIPPMANN

The lake is breathing. Can you hear it? The water is forcing air into the pipes, and you're standing here talking about "authentication."

BERNAYS

This is a six-figure payday! Do you really want to die in a chair that smells like a wet dog? Because that is your only other option!

GOODWIN

He's not saying he wants you to die, grandpapa. He's talking about the value of the deal!

LIPPMANN

The value is in the seal! If that seal breaks, the value is zero because everything will be underwater!

Bernays slams his briefcase shut.

BERNAYS

The market doesn't go underwater, Lippmann! The market is in the cloud!

LIPPMANN

Then go live in the cloud! Eat the cloud too!

A sharp, metallic CLANG echoes from deep beneath the floor. It is immediately followed by a high-pitched hiss from the radiator behind Lippmann's desk as a jet of white steam blasts out of a rusted valve.

Goodwin jumps back.

GOODWIN

Whoa! What was that? Is it supposed to do that?

BERNAYS

It's just a faulty gasket. Relax.

Bernays sniffs the air.

BERNAYS (CONT'D)

The air in here—it's like breathing a penny.

GOODWIN

I told you about the ventilation! Lippmann, tell him—

LIPPMANN

The ventilation works just fine, as long as you don't mind the smell of hard work.

BERNAYS

(Laughing)

"Work." Right. I haven't smelled work since my father's garage in Queens. Now, I only smell opportunity.

GOODWIN

He's being literal, Lippmann. The valuation on this—

LIPPMANN

You want to touch the wrench? Or are you afraid you'll get some of that "work" on your expensive cuffs?

BERNAYS

I've paid enough to earn the right to get a little grease on my hands, Mr. Lippmann.

GOODWIN

Bernays's firm handled the Brooklyn Navy Yard project, Lippmann. They understand industrial—

LIPPMANN

The Navy Yard ain't nothing but a shopping mall now.

BERNAYS

It's a "Lifestyle Hub." A big difference.

LIPPMANN

Yeah, the difference is you can't build a ship in a Hub.

BERNAYS

You can't build a ship here anymore, either.
This place is a graveyard, and I'm the guy who
pays for the headstones.

GOODWIN

Bernays, just show him the screen. Show him the
numbers—

LIPPMANN

I don't want to see a screen. I've seen enough
of them.

Bernays displays his tablet.

BERNAYS

It's not just a screen; it's a ledger. A
digital—

LIPPMANN

A ledger is a book. That thing is just a
confused lightbulb.

GOODWIN

It's zero-point-four-eight Bitcoin, Lippmann!

LIPPMANN

Is Bitcoin made of solid gold?!

GOODWIN

It's better than solid gold! It's universal
liquidity! You can take the value of this
wrench to Arizona, to Florida, to anywhere—

LIPPMANN

I can't turn a physical valve with liquidity!

GOODWIN

There won't be a valve! The pumps will be
automated.

LIPPMANN

The pumps are dead, grandson. They're analog!
They're as old as me and can't read code!

The radiator in the corner lets
out a sudden, violent THUMP. Steam
starts to hiss.

BERNAYS

What the hell is—

GOODWIN

Is that a leak?

BERNAYS

That's the lake! It's pushing into the secondary lines!

BERNAYS (CONT'D)

(Shouting over the steam)

I'm trying to give you a real life, Lippmann! A clean start—!

GOODWIN

Just sign the deal, Lippmann! Sign it before his mobile data drops!

LIPPMANN

Mobile data? You're worried about imaginary stuff while the water and steam are going mobile?!

BERNAYS

Bitcoin isn't solid either! The market is fluid!

Lippmann places a finger on the tablet, before flicking it hard.

LIPPMANN

Fluid like my snaps.

The overhead lights flicker violently in sync with the thumping pipes. The tablet flashes red: CONNECTION LOST.

The lights go out.

BERNAYS

No! No, no, no—!

GOODWIN

Did it go through? Bernays, tell me the transfer went through!

LIPPMANN

(A terrifying calm)

It didn't.

GOODWIN

Lippmann? Where are you?

BERNAYS

My tablet... Where's my— I need a light!

LIPPMANN

You don't need a light. You need a grip.

The heavy wrench hits the desk.

SCENE 2

The office is plunged into total darkness, lit only by the fading glow of Bernays's tablet and the weak beam of Goodwin's phone. The waves of the lake has intensified and shakes the desk.

It is storming outside.

BERNAYS

The power must just be out around here! The internet was working fine a couple of minutes ago. Goodwin, turn on your hotspot right now!

GOODWIN

I'm trying! But I have "No Service."

BERNAYS

The cell tower just vanished off the face of the Earth.

LIPPMANN

The tower is still there. The power grid just decided it was tired of carrying you.

BERNAYS

Lippmann, listen! The transaction is "Pending."

LIPPMANN

And?

BERNAYS

If we don't reconnect in the next moment, you are losing a thousand dollars every time a wave hits that wall!

LIPPMANN

I'm not losing a thing. I still have the iron.

GOODWIN

Grandpa. You and I know you don't get enough iron.

LIPPMANN

I eat my beans and chickpeas.

BERNAYS

Oh chicken-heads... That iron is worthless without my signature! It's scrap metal!

GOODWIN

Bernays, calm down! Grandpa, can we go to the roof? Maybe there's a signal up there?

LIPPMANN

The roof is sixty feet of rusted steel and a lightning rod that ain't been grounded in fifty years. You go up there, you're just a target.

BERNAYS

This is a stall! You think because the lights went out, you can squeeze me for more? You think the steel market is going to double? It doesn't work like that, old man!

Lippmann steps into the light. He holds the Sturgeon like a staff.

LIPPMANN

No one can steal away the spirit of American steel. You nor I. Go steal from Silicon Valley.

BERNAYS

Silicon Valley is a whole 'nother beast compared the American steel industry... I bet you'd miss out on the real Gold Rush even when it's right in front of you!

LIPPMANN

(Soliloquizing)

You kids talk about a Gold Rush like it's some holy pilgrimage. Back then, half the men in this mill were looking for an exit strategy, something light they could carry in a pocket so they didn't have to smell kerosene. They went West looking for a payday that didn't require grit.

But my ancestors stayed. They stayed because they knew you can't build a country on a fever dream. You think the future is all fiber optics and universal liquidity, but crypto ain't liquidity when the pumps stop. This iron here? It's seen every fire this nation ever lit.

My colleagues called me a fool for not chasing the digital gold. They wanted the light life. But look at your tablet now... it's just a confused lightbulb with no juice. The future ran out of batteries, Goodwin. But the Sturgeon? It doesn't need a signal to hold back the Great Lakes. It's thirty pounds of Mesabi iron and eighty years of spite. It's the only thing that works when the world goes dark.

(MORE)

LIPPMANN (CONT'D)

So, keep your heritage and your boutique hotels. I'll keep the wrench. Because when your "Gold" evaporates into the ether, someone's still gotta be here to turn the steel.

The room falls silent. Beneath the roar of the lake, there is a groan of metal stretching.

GOODWIN

What was that?

LIPPMANN

That's the sub-basement intake. The lake is trying to force its way inside.

BERNAYS

Then we're leaving! We'll drive until we find a 5G signal and finish the deal in the car.

LIPPMANN

The car may not start, Bernays.

BERNAYS

How would you know?

LIPPMANN

The front gate is electric. The power surge likely fried the motor.

BERNAYS

I'll be praying for Edison's strength.

LIPPMANN

You and I know it was Nikola Tesla's resolve.

GOODWIN

We're locked in? Lippmann, tell me you have a key!

LIPPMANN

I told you. This is the only key left in the building.

Lippmann pats the Sturgeon.

BERNAYS

(Lunging for it)

Give me that!

LIPPMANN

(Not moving an inch)

You want to hold it now, Bernays?

(MORE)

LIPPMANN (CONT'D)

Now that the "Gold" is a black screen and your shoes are getting dusty?

BERNAYS

I have a legal right to that wrench! The intent to buy was established!

GOODWIN

(Stepping between them)

Bernays, back off! Lippmann, he's just-everyone's just tense.

LIPPMANN

He's not tense. He's realizing the future is a thin coat of paint. And the paint is peeling.

The blue light of the tablet is fading. The water pools around their shoes.

BERNAYS

(Frantically typing)

The signal's not dead, it's just-it's buffered. If I can just get to the-

GOODWIN

There is no "buffered," Bernays! The router's in the admin block and that block is probably underwater-

LIPPMANN

Admin's built on a sinkhole. First thing to go. You want to save your "Gold," you better start praying to the-

BERNAYS

(Shouting over Lippmann)

Don't tell me what to pray to! I have forty-eight-thousand dollars of my own collateral tied to this transaction! If this doesn't verify-

GOODWIN

Your collateral? You said this was a clean acquisition!

BERNAYS

It's a leverage play! Everything's a leverage play! I've got a buyer in Grand Rapids who wants the heritage iron and I've got a margin call screaming-

LIPPMANN

(Laughing)

Heritage. You hear that, Sturgeon? You're not a tool anymore. You're *heritage*.

GOODWIN

Shut up, grandpa!

(to Bernays)

So what happens if the power doesn't come back on? What happens to the transfer?

BERNAYS

(Voice cracking)

It times out. It goes back into the ether. And I go into a hole.

Lippmann steps closer, with the Sturgeon held low.

LIPPMANN

Welcome to the hole, Bernays. It's cold, it's wet, and there isn't a 5G bar in sight.

A massive BOOM echoes from below—the sound of a high-pressure seal failing. A new, deeper vibration takes hold of the office. The water on the floor begins to move in a current toward the door.

GOODWIN

(Screaming)

What was that?

LIPPMANN

That was the secondary gate. The lake just pushed through the masonry.

Bernays grabs his tablet.

BERNAYS

We have to go. We have to go now. Forget the wrench, Goodwin, grab the bag—

Lippmann blocks the door.

LIPPMANN

(Blocking the door)

You go out that door, you're in a hallway that's a wind tunnel. You won't make the stairs. The only way to stop the surge is the valve—

BERNAYS

I don't care about the valve! I care about my life!

LIPPMANN

They're the same thing now! You wanna live? Help me turn the iron!

GOODWIN

(Caught between them)

Bernays, he's right—look at the water! It's rising!

BERNAYS

(Lunging for the door)

Move, you crazy old—

Lippmann doesn't move. He plants the Sturgeon like a spear. Bernays stops inches from the steel.

LIPPMANN

One hundred and twelve thousand dollars of "nothing" vs. thirty pounds of "something." Make a choice, Bernays. Before the lake makes it for you.

GOODWIN

(Looking at the door)

The water's coming under the frame, Lippmann. It's not just pooling, it's—it's flowing.

Bernays grips his briefcase like a life preserver.

BERNAYS

We go up. We go to the roof and we wait for the city—

LIPPMANN

The city isn't coming for a dead mill, Bernays. They've got ten thousand basements in the Heights flooding right now. You want to wait? You'll be driftwood.

GOODWIN

What do we do? Tell us what to do!

Lippmann shoves the Sturgeon into Goodwin's hands.

LIPPMANN

Carry it.

GOODWIN
(Staggering)

Me?

LIPPMANN
You're the one who wanted to sell it. Now
you're gonna carry it to work.
(to Bernays)
Grab that light. And don't drop it.

BERNAYS
I'm not a sherpa! I'm a partner in—

Lippmann grabs Bernays by the
lapel, inches from his face.

LIPPMANN
Right now, you're a flashlight. Hold it steady
or I leave you in the dark to see if your
golden glows.

They exit the office. The
soundscape changes instantly. The
office was a drum; the hallway is
a cathedral of screaming metal.
The BEAM of Bernays's tablet light
cuts through a thick mist of
steam.

GOODWIN
(Shouting over the roar)
I CAN'T SEE THE STEPS!

LIPPMANN
FEEL FOR THE RIDGES! HAND ON THE RAIL!

Bernays slips and makes a splash.

BERNAYS
THE WATER'S FREEZING! IT'S—IT'S ICE WATER!

LIPPMANN
THAT'S THE LAKE, BERNAYS! IT DOESN'T HAVE A
HEATER!

GOODWIN
THE WRENCH! IT'S GETTING HEAVIER! I CAN'T—

LIPPMANN
DON'T YOU DROP IT! IF THAT IRON HITS THE
BOTTOM, WE'RE ALL GHOSTS!

The black and oily water is at
their waists.

Suddenly, a violent surge in the current knocks Bernays against the rusted wall. His tablet light sweeps wildly across the surface.

BERNAYS

(A high-pitched scream)

SOMETHING TOUCHED ME! UNDER THE WATER!

GOODWIN

It's just debris, Bernays! Keep the light on the—

BERNAYS

NO! IT'S MOVING! IT'S ALIVE!

Bernays sweeps the tablet light downward. The beam reveals a five-foot Lake Sturgeon wedged between the stairs and a cooling pipe. Its armored scutes glisten. The fish thrashes, slamming its tail against the metal with the force of a hammer.

GOODWIN

(Backing away, gasping)

God... what is that? It looks like a dinosaur!

BERNAYS

It's a shark! It's going to take my leg off!
Get me out of here!

Lippmann steps forward with eyes locked on the fish.

LIPPMANN

He's got no teeth, fool. A Lake Sturgeon.

Lippmann reaches out a hand, almost touching the thrashing tail.

LIPPMANN (CONT'D)

The lake sent a messenger to see if we're still here.

GOODWIN

Lippmann, it's huge. It's blocking the path to the header!

LIPPMANN

(to the fish)

Easy now, old man. We're just passing through.

Lippmann looks back at Goodwin,
who is gripping the iron wrench.
He looks from the armored fish to
the notched head of the tool.

LIPPMANN (CONT'D)

You wanted to know why I named it Sturgeon?
Look at him. He survived the glaciers. He
survived the nets. He's iron. He's American.
Lives to be 150. And right now, he's just as
stuck in this chaos as we are.

BERNAYS

(Teeth chattering)

I don't care about biology! It's a lawsuit
waiting to happen!

LIPPMANN

(Barking)

THEN HOLD THE LIGHT STEADY!

Lippmann seizes the iron Sturgeon
and uses its handle to nudge the
fish's snout. With a swirl of
silt, the creature slips past
Bernays's legs and vanishes into
the darkness.

LIPPMANN

(Pointing to the far wall)

THERE! THE MAIN HEADER! THE FISH IS GONE,
BERNAYS! GET YOUR CASHMERE IN THE GREASE AND
PULL! BOTH OF YOU! GRAB THE STEEL!

The three are huddled around the
valve. The blue light of the
tablet is flickering out—battery
at 1%. In the dying light, they
look like a sculpture of a
forgotten era. Goodwin and Bernays
have their hands on the cold,
black iron of the Sturgeon.
Lippmann is behind them, his arms
wrapped around both, bracing them.

LIPPMANN

On three!

GOODWIN

(Sobbing)

It won't move!

LIPPMANN

(Screaming)

It has to! Pull for the past! Pull for the life
you want!

BERNAYS

(A primal scream)

UUGGGHHHHHHHH!

LIPPMANN

One! Two! Three!

A sound like a gunshot—CRACK. The
valve moves an inch. A jet of
black sludge sprays Bernays's
face.

LIPPMANN

Keep. Turning.

The tablet screen goes black.
Total darkness.

SCENE 3

STEEL MILL BASEMENT

Total darkness. The only sound is the mechanical clank of the Sturgeon's head ratcheting against the valve. The roar of the water has changed from a scream to a draining gurgle.

GOODWIN

(Panting)

Is it... is it moving? I can't feel my arms.

LIPPMANN

(His voice strained)

The seal is cracked. Keep the torque steady. Don't let it slip now, or the pressure will take your hands off.

BERNAYS

My palms... the iron is cutting through the leather. I'm bleeding on this thing.

LIPPMANN

Let it cut! That's the feeling of being alive, Bernays! That's eighty years of Mesabi iron calling you back to the earth!

The valve hits the stopper.

GOODWIN

IT BOTTOMED! IT'S OPEN!

A whoosh as the pressure vents. The water around their waists begins to swirl, spinning in a vortex toward the floor drains. The vibration in the walls stops.

BERNAYS

(Whispering)

The light... my tablet... where is the light?

GOODWIN

(Fumbling)

My phone's gone. It fell in the sludge... it's all gone.

Lippmann strikes a Zippo. The tiny flame flickers, casting long, dancing shadows of the three exhausted figures.

LIPPMANN

You don't need a screen to see what's right in front of you.

Bernays looks down. His hands are stained coal. The blood from his palms mixes with century's old grease.

BERNAYS

The Bitcoin... the market cratered. I saw the alert just before the signal died.

GOODWIN

Bernays, we almost drowned. The money doesn't matter.

BERNAYS

It's the only thing that matters! I'm ruined! I have a mortgage in Brooklyn, a firm to answer to—I'm a dead man!

Lippmann closes the Zippo, dropping it into the receding muck.

LIPPMANN

You have your life. And you have the tool.

BERNAYS

(Screaming)

THE TOOL IS SCRAP! WE USED IT! IT'S SPENT!

LIPPMANN

A tool isn't spent until it breaks. And this iron doesn't know how to break.

The sun begins to rise.

A light filters down through the cracked windows of the sub-basement, catching the mist. The water is gone, leaving a layer of silt and industrial debris.

Bernays slumps against a rusted pillar, staring at his dead, mud-caked tablet. Goodwin stands over the wrench, mesmerized.

GOODWIN

What happens now, Lippmann? The power is still out. The whole city is a blackout.

Lippmann walks over to the Sturgeon, placing a hand on it.

LIPPMANN

Now? We wait for the sun to get high enough to see the mess. Then, we start cleaning.

BERNAYS

(Without looking up)

Cleaning? For what? There's no market for this.

LIPPMANN

The market's closed, Bernays. But the building is standing. Goodwin, you wanted to see the future? Look at the wrench. It survived the fire of '52, the freeze of '75, and it just survived your digital gold.

GOODWIN

(Touching the handle)

Still heavy.

LIPPMANN

Still real.

BERNAYS

I had a party planned in Grand Rapids at ten tonight. First class. Pre-boarding. Champagne. Now I'm standing in a basement that smells like a tailpipe.

GOODWIN

At least you're standing and the steel mill is.

Lippmann looks at the Sturgeon in Goodwin's hand. Then at her tear-streaked, soot-covered face.

LIPPMANN

You're right, Goodwin. The mill is standing. But your father... he's still gasping for air in a house that smells like this basement.

GOODWIN

I just want him to taste a copper-less morning without losing a penny.

Lippmann turns to Bernays, who is shivering in his ruined cashmere.

Goodwin places the Sturgeon in
Bernays's hands.

GOODWIN (CONT'D)

Take the heritage.

LIPPMANN

Tell those people in Grand Rapids that this
iron didn't just build the rails. Tell them it
held back the Great Lakes tonight.

GOODWIN

(Gasping)

Grandpa? You're... really selling it?

LIPPMANN

I'm not selling a wrench, little fish. I'm
trading a piece of the past so your dad can
have a future. The Sturgeon has one last job:
it's going to buy him a breath of fresh air.

Bernays grips the handle. His
voice is steady for the first
time.

BERNAYS

The crypto market is dead for today, Lippmann.
But my firm has a private foundation for
industrial preservation. I'll make sure the
grant covers every specialist, every tank, and
every bill. This is no leverage play anymore.
It's a debt of honor.

LIPPMANN

Then get it out of here. Before I change my
mind and use it to crack open your head.

BERNAYS

(A smirk)

Yes, sir.

GOODWIN

Thank you.

LIPPMANN

Don't thank me yet. We still have to get that
electric gate open.

Lippmann produces a rusted manual
crank from his pocket and hands it
Bernays.

LIPPMANN (CONT'D (CONT'D)

...you're the motor now, flashlight. Let's go.

The light through the windows
turns a piercing gold. The dust
motes in the air look like sparks
from a forge. Goodwin looks at the
Sturgeon, then out at the skyline.

GOODWIN

If the lights don't come back on... what do we
do tomorrow?

LIPPMANN

(Turning toward the stairs)

The same thing the men who signed that Log did.
We find where the world is stuck. And we crack
it open.

Beat.

Bernays looks at his dead tablet,
then at Lippman and Goodwin. He
slowly reaches down and wipes a
streak of black grease across his
own forehead, a mark of the
basement.

BERNAYS

Fine. But I'm not cleaning toilets.

LIPPMANN

(From the stairs)

We'll see. The Sturgeon hasn't given you orders
yet.

Goodwin follows Lippmann, carrying
the Sturgeon over her shoulder.
Bernays lingers for a second,
leaves his tablet in the mud, and
follows them up into the light.

Black out.

END OF PLAY